MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 3 — Unit 4: Utopia - Sir Thomas More

CHAUCER TO THE ELIZABETHAN AGE

Expanded exam notes · Simple explanations + developed discussion

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material (M21EG01DC). These are study aids, not the original textbook. Everyday comparisons are teaching examples. The original notes and full textbook units remain available in the subject folder.

The chapter in one sentence

Thomas More uses an invented island to make readers question inequality, government, property, punishment, and the cost of an apparently ideal society.

Start with a picture

Imagine being asked to design a new town. Would people own everything separately or share resources? Who would do unpleasant work? Could people travel freely? More turns questions like these into a conversation about a fictional island.

1. What is Utopia?

Utopia was first published in Latin in 1516; an English translation appeared in 1551. The title plays with the idea of a “no-place” and the suggestion of a good place. The island is imagined, not a country readers can visit.

A fictional character named More appears in the work. He is not simply an unfiltered statement of everything the historical author believed.

2. Who is speaking?

- **More:** a participant in the framing conversation.
- **Peter Giles:** helps connect the participants.
- **Raphael Hythloday:** a traveller who describes the island and criticises European society.
- **Utopus:** the island’s founding ruler in the account.

A **dialogue** allows viewpoints to meet and disagree. This matters because the book does not give every idea the same unquestioned authority.

3. Book I: look at the problems at home

Hythloday discusses government, advisers, inequality, and punishment. He questions rulers who prefer flattering advice and warfare to the welfare of their people.

He also questions the harsh punishment of theft. If economic arrangements push people into poverty, punishing them without addressing the cause does not solve the larger problem.

Everyday comparison: imagine a school that provides no lunch but severely punishes hungry children for taking food. A fair discussion must ask about the conditions producing the behaviour, not only the final act.

The critique of enclosure links the transformation of land use with dispossession and poverty.

4. Book II: imagine another arrangement

Hythloday describes a society with shared resources rather than ordinary private property. Work, farming, education, housing, and public life are organised collectively. The account includes a six-hour working day and time for learning.

Gold is deliberately treated in ways that reduce its prestige. This challenges the assumption that something is valuable simply because people admire its price.

The island’s arrangements expose how customs shape desire. If a community stopped treating expensive objects as status symbols, people might compete for them less.

5. Why “perfect society” is not enough

Utopia also contains coercive features, including slavery, restrictions on travel, and strict regulation of social life. Religious toleration has limits. The reader should ask who benefits, who obeys, and who is excluded.

These tensions are part of the work’s importance. It is too simple to say, “More invented a flawless society and told us to copy every rule.” The dialogue, satire, and disagreements complicate that conclusion.

6. Major themes

- **Justice:** laws should be examined in relation to social conditions.
- **Property and inequality:** private wealth can conflict with common welfare.
- **Reason:** customs should be questioned rather than accepted automatically.
- **Freedom and order:** collective wellbeing can come with restrictions.
- **Satire:** an invented world exposes problems in the real one.

Remember these words

- **Commonwealth:** a political community considered in relation to shared welfare.
- **Enclosure:** conversion of commonly used or open land into enclosed holdings, often disrupting livelihoods.
- **Utopian:** concerned with an imagined better social order.
- **Dystopian:** concerned with an oppressive or deeply undesirable social order.

Build an exam answer

Explain the two-book structure, give two criticisms of Europe, describe two island institutions, and analyse one contradiction. Keep Hythloday, the fictional More, and the historical author distinct.

Quick check

1. Is Utopia a real island? **No.**
2. Why discuss the causes of theft? **To connect individual acts with social arrangements.**
3. Can Utopia be read critically? **Yes; its restrictions and exclusions complicate its ideal appearance.**

Develop an exam answer

Practice question

How does Utopia use an imaginary society to criticise real institutions?

Expanded discussion

Utopia makes social criticism possible through comparison. In Book I, Hythloday's reflections direct attention towards the relation between inequality, government policy, and punishment. His discussion of theft challenges the idea that harsh penalties alone can produce a just society. If people are deprived of a livelihood, the conditions leading to crime must also be examined. The argument therefore moves from an individual offence to the organisation of the community.

Book II provides an imagined alternative through shared resources, organised labour, education, and the reduced prestige of precious metals. These arrangements question whether familiar practices are natural or merely customary. Treating gold as socially insignificant, for example, exposes the dependence of status on collective agreement. The island thus operates as an intellectual experiment rather than simply an exotic background for adventure.

However, the imagined alternative contains serious restrictions. Slavery, regulated movement, and close control over life complicate the picture of collective wellbeing. Equality within one arrangement may depend on exclusions or coercion elsewhere. A critical account should therefore ask whose freedom is protected and whose is limited. These tensions make the work richer than a straightforward blueprint for an ideal state.

The dialogue form also prevents easy identification of one voice with the author's final judgement. Hythloday's claims, the fictional More's responses, and the historical author's act of constructing the discussion must be distinguished. Utopia can consequently be read as an invitation to reason about institutions: it destabilises complacency while leaving readers to confront the difficulties of reform.

Suggested answer structure

1. Explain dialogue and two-book structure

2. Book I: inequality and punishment
3. Book II: property, work, and education
4. Examine coercion and exclusion
5. Evaluate satire rather than a perfect blueprint

Common mistakes to avoid

Do not identify every claim by Hythloday with More’s personal beliefs. Include contradictions rather than describing the island as flawless.

Turn this into your own answer

Read the question again and choose only relevant sections. Make one clear point per paragraph, explain it, and connect it with a specific textual detail. Add accurate short quotations from the textbook where useful; the discussion above is paraphrase, not quoted text. Adjust length to the marks and time available.

Coverage review: extra exam details

Everyday institutions: short-answer details

The supplied account describes similarly arranged cities and houses, gardens, and unlocked entrances. These details connect domestic space with the absence of ordinary private ownership. Clothing is relatively uniform, with distinctions for sex and marital status rather than constant fashion competition. Work and farming are widely shared responsibilities; the six-hour working day leaves space for education and other regulated activities.

Hythloday refuses the proposed role of royal counsellor because he doubts that rulers and their advisers will accept unwelcome truths. The issue is the relation between honest advice and political power, not simply his dislike of employment. The fictional More’s engagement with the argument keeps the question open rather than supplying one uncontested solution.

Priests: checked against Book II

The textbook asks about priests without giving much explanation. In Book II, the priests are few, elected by the people through secret votes, and highly honoured for their piety. They oversee worship and moral guidance and take particular responsibility for forming the young people’s character. Civil punishment belongs to magistrates, although exclusion from worship is itself socially powerful. Priests may marry, and women can become priests in rare circumstances described in the work. Their exceptional immunity from ordinary punishment is a point for critical discussion, not proof that the island has no hierarchy. Source: Thomas More, Utopia, Book II, discussion of religions, Project Gutenberg ebook 2130, consulted through the GITenberg mirror.

When discussing common property, do not import every institution of a modern political system into a sixteenth-century fiction simply because an older survey calls it communist. Describe the island’s actual arrangements and the contradictions of its coercive practices.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts, included as a revision checklist, not as predictions of the exam. Longer answers still need evidence from the assigned texts.

1. What picture of the Utopian society do you get from this book?
2. Why does Hythloday refuse to become a King’s Counselor?
3. How are houses constructed in Utopia?
4. What do you know about the islanders’ costume?
5. What was the islanders’ attitude towards priests?